

■ By Elora Sen

It used to be one of the most unforgettable sights from the height of the Indian summer: thousands of the world-famous Olive Ridley turtles waddling out of the water to nest and breed on the pristine white sand beaches of Gahirmatha in Orissa on magical, moonlit nights. Not just the Olive Ridelys, most other species of turtle also emerge of their hibernation spanning winters and begin mating and looking for proper nesting places. This mass movement, typical of the turtles, is ironically what has made them even more vulnerable. Mating season for this animal, which is believed to have outlived every other prehistoric species of reptile, has also become prime poaching season.

Extensive surveys by the Wildlife Society of Orissa (wso) have revealed that the once abundant freshwater turtles are now facing extinction, not only in Orissa but elsewhere in India too. According to a wso study, as many as five out of the 11 species of freshwater turtles typically found in Orissa, no longer exist in the Mahanadi river, which once used to be their main habitat. Rampant poaching, encouraged by illegal trade, is believed to have resulted in their dwindling numbers.

The reptiles are mostly caught at the delta heads of this river—Dhabaleswar, Mundali, Padmavati and Kantilo and also in the upstream river of Cuttack. Also, distributaries like Chitropala and Luna are happy hunting grounds for poachers.

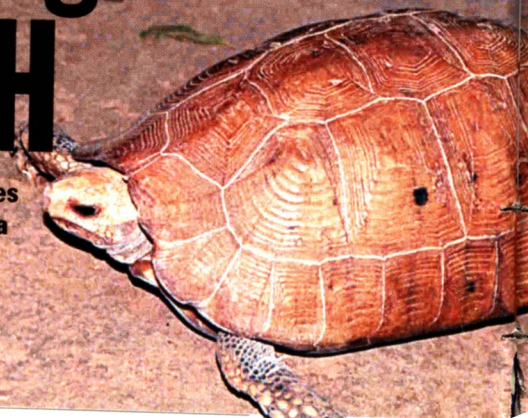
With most of the riverbeds drying up in summer months and reducing water levels in many, it becomes easy for poachers to spot the animal. With May 23 having been celebrated as the World Turtle Day, environmentalists plan to focus on saving the animal and push their programme for turtle conservation to a higher level.

It promises to be an uphill task. Despite an official ban, turtle meat continues to be sought after and sold openly even now in rural Bengal, especially in pockets of Midnapore. "Almost without exception, all consignments that have been nabbed by the officials of the Orissa Forest Department were meant for traders in West Bengal," claims Biswajit Mohanty, secretary of



Crawling towards DEATH

Five out of the 11 species of turtles found in Orissa no longer exist, taking the conservation of the endangered species to a critical state



wso. Mohanty has been involved in wildlife conservation in Orissa for 14 years and is also a member of the National Board of Wildlife. A chartered accountant by profession, Mohanty has kept his focus trained on turtle conservation since 1998.

The very idea of turtle conservation seemed incongruous as recently as two decades ago. Till the late '70s, turtle meat was openly sold in the fish markets lining the lanes of Kolkata. It was considered a delicacy, with locals vouching that its taste was better than mutton. It was more affordable and was said to have a high nutrition quotient. Such qualities only served to fuel the demand for turtle meat and endangered the turtle population in the state

and across the borders in Orissa. Only the Indian tent roofed turtle is not targeted by poachers as its meat is not edible.

Today, a quick round of the major markets of Kolkata, does not show blatant sales of turtle meat. Mohanty claims that the trade is being carried on surreptitiously in Kolkata through home deliveries at the rate of Rs 40 to Rs 50 per kg. The fact that capturing, killing or selling freshwater turtle is punishable under the Wildlife Protection Act has not really been a deterrent so far.

With marine turtles being on the World Wildlife Fund's (wwf) list of endangered species, their conserva-